



STANDING TALL:
Somaraj (in green
shirt) and Pearson
(third from right)

The Ride of Their Lives

Two ordinary men start a bus service which transforms a small village by giving its youth a future

■ By J. Binduraj

As the managing partner of the Janavedi Transport Corporation (JTC), Somaraj has little time to spare. The 28-year-old, who controls assets worth over Rs 2 crore, oversees two bus terminals and 22 buses which travel most of the main routes in and out of Pooyapilli village of Ernakulam district, Kerala. All this he manages, while doubling up as a driver or a conductor on one of the buses the corporation plies.

Life was not always like this. Ten years ago, Somaraj, like many of the unemployed youth in Pooyapilli, was making do with sundry jobs. His father's untimely death forced him to give up studies and support his family of four. The only respite, for many in his condition, was to take refuge in local politics, but Somaraj took to toddy tapping.

He continued to struggle until N.M. Pearson, a teacher in a non-regular college in the village, came to the rescue. "Some villagers wanted to liberate them from exploitation, so we wondered what we could do in a constructive way," he recalls. It was then that the idea of starting a bus service struck Pearson and Somaraj. There were not many buses in the remote village and people found it difficult to reach the nearest big town during emergencies. The service



would fulfill a very real need.

Managing to collect Rs 60,000, eight villagers, including Somaraj and Pearson, approached Tata Finance for help to launch JTC as a co-operative bus transport venture. It was a challenge and a gamble as they had to remit more than half of their earnings towards the repayment of the loan. But soon they realised that by adding to their fleet of

buses, they could not only increase revenue but also generate jobs for unemployed youth. With this expansion, there was no looking back. JTC today employs more than 100 people in the village. "We also give part-time jobs to college students. They earn a minimum of Rs 900 a month by washing our vehicles," says Somaraj.

JTC has begun to diversify its activities. It has purchased an acre of land for fish-farming. Undertaking projects under the People's Planning Programme—a rural empowerment programme for local bodies—its employees earn money for the corporation to help repay the initial loan. And to thank its villagers, JTC plans to give a 50 per cent concession on bus charges as a tenth anniversary offer. Not forgetting what motivated them to start this service, the employees always find time to offer help to people in medical emergencies. Seems this is the road to success for this village. ■